important than the chain of command.

Raising a forefinger, automatically but politely, I pointed out that before I emailed above my station, I'd *tried* the chain of command and been failed by it. Which was precisely the last thing I should have been explaining to the chain of command itself, personified just across a desk from me.

The head of the school just stared at his shoes and occasionally glanced out the window.

"Listen," his boss said. "Ed, I'm not here to file a 'hurt feelings report.' Relax. I recognize that you're a talented guy, and we've gone around and talked to all of your instructors and they say you're talented and sharp. Even volunteered for the war zone. That's something we appreciate. We want you here, but we need to know that we can count on you. You've got to understand that there's a system here. Sometimes we've all got to put up with things we don't like, because the mission comes first, and we can't complete that mission if every guy on the team is second-guessing." He took a pause, swallowed, and said, "Nowhere is this more true than in the desert. A lot of things happen out in the desert, and I'm not sure that we're at a stage yet where I'm comfortable you'll know how to handle them."

This was their gotcha, their retaliation. And though it was entirely self-defeating, the head of the school was now smiling at the parking lot. No one besides me—and I mean no one—had put down SRD, or any other active combat situation for that matter, as their first or second or even third choice on their dream sheets. Everyone else had prioritized all the stops on the European champagne circuit, all the neat sweet vacation-station burgs with windmills and bicycles, where you rarely hear explosions.

Almost perversely, they now gave me one of these assignments. They gave me Geneva. They punished me by giving me what I'd never asked for, but what everybody else had wanted.

As if he were reading my mind, the director said, "This isn't a punishment, Ed. It's an opportunity—really. Someone with your level of expertise would be wasted in the war zone. You need a bigger station, that pilots the newest projects, to really keep you busy and stretch your skills."

Everybody in class who'd been congratulating me would later turn jealous and think that I'd been bought off with a luxury position to avoid further complaints. My reaction, in the moment, was the opposite: I thought that the head of the school must have had an informant in the class, who'd told him exactly the type of station I'd hoped to avoid.